

**SEMANTIC DECODING OF ENGLISH MIX-CODE IN THE WORLD OF
VIETNAMESE YOUTH MUSIC (2018 – 2023)**

**Giải mã ngữ nghĩa của “mã trộn” tiếng Anh trong thế giới nhạc trẻ Việt Nam
(2018 – 2023)**

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ABSTRACT

This study investigates and analyzes the semantic features of the foreign language elements appearing in 435 Vietnamese pop songs uploaded on YouTube from 2018 to 2023. The study considers code-mixing as a intentional expressive device that is organized according to the grammatical structure and motivated by the socio-cultural factors, based on the theoretical frameworks of Gumperz (1982), Myers-Scotton (1993), and Muysken (2000). The results of the surveying, classification, and semantic analysis processes reveal that the code-mixed units cover various semantic domains reflecting the diversity and flexibility of modern musical language. It can be asserted that code-mixing is not merely a formal linguistic blending, but rather a meaning-making process in which each foreign lexical item functions as an expressive focal point, enriching the emotional nuance of the lyrics. The combination of Vietnamese and global languages enables singers and songwriters to construct personal identity while simultaneously embodying the spirit of cultural integration in Vietnamese music within the digital era. Accordingly, this study contributes to clarifying the role of code-mixing as both a manifestation of linguistic creativity and a medium of cultural hybridity distinctive to contemporary Vietnamese pop music.

Keywords: *code-mixing, semantics, Vietnamese pop music, cultural hybridity, youth identity*

1. Introduction

Sociolinguists these days focus on the actual language used in day-to-day lives, which shows a different research direction when comparing to the past (Trần Thị Phương Lý & Cao Kim Vy, 2020). To be more specific, while older structural approaches viewed language as a solid, rigid, and static system, sociolinguists nowadays concentrate on how speakers change and stretch language to fit whatever situations they are in. This is exactly where code-mixing fits. It is highly the case that code-mixing is the natural way bilingual speakers blend different languages together. For the bilinguals, it assists in constructing meaning, conveying precise feelings and expressing who they are. Code-mixing was often looked down upon in the past.

In the past, code-mixing was often looked down on. Many saw it as a sign of being obsessed with foreign languages, or simply as a failure to speak a native tongue correctly (Nguyễn Văn Khang, 2012). Today, that view has changed. As our world becomes increasingly integrated, linguists recognize that blending language might be acceptable, and it is the unique way ones can express their identity (Wardhaugh & Fuller, 2021). Blending two languages does not mean a speaker has a limited vocabulary, it actually gives them wider range of expression. It allows them to convey specific, quiet emotions that a single language might fail to capture.

Vietnamese youth music shows exactly how creative language can get. A variety of foreign languages, including English, Korean, Japanese, and Chinese have been recorded to appear in Vietnamese songs since 2018. Many artists recognize that mixing these languages together help them express their personal feelings and style easier, so now the multilingual style in songwriting might be a standard part in the industry,

The purpose of this research goes beyond simply analyzing sentence structures, understand how the language choices affect the actual meaning of the song and how artists use them to communicate. Because pop music spreads quickly online, giving young people a relaxed space to experiment with words, so by ignoring traditional grammar rules, artists

use mixed lyrics to define who they are and establish their own musical style. By examining these songs, we get a clearer picture of how Vietnamese youth adapt language and culture to find their place in a connected world.

2. Literature Review

2.1. International Studies

Code-mixing receives later focus comparing other linguistic, Hymes (1963, as cited in Nguyễn Văn Khang, 2012) was one of the first to treat mixed languages with respect. He commented that they are just normal ways people adapt their speech in everyday conversations. Moreover, Akhmanova (1966, as cited in Bùi Khánh Thế, 2010) pointed out that code-mixing goes far beyond changing simple words, it can shape sentence structures, shifts meanings, and influence how people tell stories. This perspective can help us see language mixing as a meaningful way of communicating with other people.

The concept of code-switching was viewed as a communication strategy by Gumperz (1982). According to him, code-switching is adopted strategically by individuals in order to communicate their attitude towards people or things, to associate themselves with certain groups of people, or for bringing a degree of complexity in the message conveyed through it. Elaborating further on this theory, Myers-Scotton (1993) developed the Matrix Language Framework that showed that code-switching follows specific rules and maintains the grammatical rules of the matrix language despite the use of lexical elements from other languages.

The linguistic notion of code-mixing has received less attention than many other traditional linguistic concepts from scholars; however, since the middle of the twentieth century, it has increasingly gained importance within academia. One of the first proponents of equality between languages was Hymes (as cited in Nguyễn Văn Khang, 2012), who viewed "mixed languages" as normal social phenomena that occur in communication. Language contact does not only involve the borrowing of vocabulary from one language into another but also greatly affects syntax, semantics, and discourse, thus forming the foundation for the study of code-mixing as a socio-semantic interaction.

From a communicative perspective, Gumperz (1982) conceptualized code-switching as a conscious pragmatic choice made by speakers for encoding their views, stance, and semantic nuance in a conversation. This line of research led Carol Myers-Scotton (1993) to introduce the Matrix Language Framework approach, demonstrating that code-switching is governed by syntactic patterns and follows the organizing patterns of the language which dominates. Concurrently, Pieter Muysken (2000), in *Bilingual Speech: A Typology of Code-Switching*, proposed that code-switching could be categorized into three primary categories, namely insertion, alternation, and congruent lexicalization.

Sociolinguistically speaking, according to Auer (Ed., 1998), besides indicating bilingual skills, code mixing also denotes social awareness and the zeitgeist itself. In terms of artistic fields, and especially when referring to music, code mixing can be seen as a means of producing aesthetical meaning. According to Babalola & Taiwo (2009) and Balogun & Murana (2021), in Nigerian hip-hop, language code mixing is performed as a form of style and identity expression of the artists' social stance. Likewise, according to Likhitphongsathorn & Sappapan (2013) studying Thai pop music, the inclusion of English songs acts both as a means of globalizing and as an emotional means of describing modernity.

In most cases, the global research community argues that code-mixing is a rule-bound activity in language with semantic and cultural significance. Code-mixing acts as a tool whereby languages can be deployed for the purpose of enriching the meaning, creating aesthetic effects, and expressing the social identity of the speaker.

2.2. Vietnamese Studies

Code-mixing is one of the phenomena that has drawn attention mainly in terms of sociolinguistics. The key role in establishing the foundations of code-mixing research was played by such studies as Cao Xuân Hạo (2001) and Nguyễn Thiện Giáp (2008). They present Vietnamese as an open language that can absorb foreign components while undergoing development. Another important study carried out by Nguyễn Văn Khang (2012) set the course for studying code-mixing as the result of social-cultural changes in urban environments where several languages are spoken.

The recent studies, such as *A Survey of Code-Mixing in English Majors' Communication at the University of Commerce* (Bùi Thị Thu Trang, 2025) and *The Phenomenon of Code-Mixing in Online Newspaper Headlines* (Lê Thị Thùy Vinh, Trần Thu Huyền, & Nguyễn Thị Thanh, 2023) prove that code-mixing is the embodiment of the era. Moreover, the research conducted by the group of Trần Thị Phương Lý & Cao Kim Vy (Saigon University) of the Vietnamese-English communication at Bến Thành Market shows that code-mixing is not only a technique used to communicate efficiently but also an extremely flexible instrument of conveying messages. As for pop music, a research team consisting of Vũ Ngọc Tiên, Quang Đăng Như Ý, Đỗ Thị Khánh Linh, Nguyễn Hoàng Kim Ngân, and Nguyễn Thị Hồng Hạnh—students of Faculty of Social Sciences and Arts at Saigon University (under the supervision of Dr. Trần Thị Lam Thủy)—has opened a new page in the field of Vietnamese pop music research through investigating the phenomenon of linguistic code-mixing. However, some issues remain untouched.

However, previous studies still seem to be predominantly concentrated on socio-pragmatic aspects and have not succeeded in revealing the meaning and purpose of code-mixing in Vietnamese youth music as a language sphere that is rich in creative energy and symbolic connotation. This leads to the suggestion that the current study could follow another direction and attempt to explore code-mixing not only in terms of linguistic structure but also as a meaningful system contributing to the construction of Vietnamese youth's linguistic identity in the era of globalization.

3. Methodology

3.1. Methodological Orientation

The study is situated in the theoretical context of sociolinguistics and draws upon semantic-discourse analysis in order to examine how linguistic components are structured and made meaningful through their relationship to each other within the lyrics of popular Vietnamese songs that target youth. The study makes use of a two-tiered research design involving a quantitative approach where data on usage trends and frequency of semantic

field occurrences will be used along with a qualitative approach where discourse analysis is used to discover the value generated from code-mixing.

By doing so, this study allows us to explore code-mixing from both perspectives not only from a structural but a functional perspective as well. In addition, it provides us with a window into the world of Vietnam's youth through the lens of popular music.

3.2. Data Sources and Sampling Criteria

The corpus for this research comprises 431 Vietnamese youth songs released between 2018 and 2023, selected from the digital music platform YouTube. The selection criteria include:

- (1) Songs containing foreign linguistic elements (primarily English);
- (2) Lyrics that clearly exhibit language blending within structure or communicative context;
- (3) Songs that have achieved significant media exposure or popularity among young audiences.

4. Findings and Discussion

4.1. The Concepts of Code and code-mixing

Code is defined as the set of symbols or rules used in communicating messages from one individual to another through the use of symbols. "Code" not only covers natural languages such as Vietnamese and English but also covers signal code, musical code, visual code, electronic code and many others. Language code is defined as the system of symbols of a language used for communication by a certain community, including writing system, sounds, vocabulary, grammar, and expressive means of a specific language. In simple terms, language code can be regarded as the communicative rule system of a particular linguistic community.

In the field of sociolinguistics, code is seen not just as a means of transmitting information from one individual to another but as an identifier of culture and social identity. Hymes (1974) postulated that language choice depends on communicative situations, depending on the nature of relation between speaker and discourse community. According

to Auer (1998), the code should be viewed as a discourse strategy which positions oneself in a multilingual environment.

In relation to such a strategy, code-mixing emerges as an inevitable manifestation of communication. According to Myers-Scotton (1993), code-mixing is considered a purposeful linguistic choice, which reflects negotiations and identity management in terms of sociocultural relations among participants in conversation. Additionally, Muysken (2000) emphasizes that code-mixing occurs when syntactic and lexical items from several languages get systematically combined into one utterance, thus exemplifying the communicative and linguistic creativity of bilinguals.

Vietnamese sociolinguist Nguyễn Văn Khang (2012) studies the process of code-mixing from a sociolinguistic point of view by perceiving this linguistic process as the interconnection between language, culture, and speech styles, including code-switching and borrowing. Moreover, Bokamba (1988) makes a distinction between those two concepts, according to which the former denotes a complete change in the use of language, while the latter refers to the integration of morphological and lexical units of several languages within one utterance.

Based on the works of Bokamba (1988) and Myers-Scotton (1993), this paper defines code-mixing as a process through which an individual consciously uses multiple language codes in one speech utterance as a means of constructing meaning and identity, as well as expressing emotion.

4.2. Overview of Vietnamese Youth Music

Popular music, also known in Vietnamese as nhạc trẻ, represents a kind of popular music that captures the spirituality, emotions, and identities of the current youth in the context of modern society. According to Simon Frith (1981), youth music does not only constitute an entertaining music genre but also plays an integral role in the development of identities through urbanization. Characteristics of pop music include a melodic tune, a rhythmic beat, and lyrics that mostly revolve around issues that have something to do with love, aspiration, loneliness, and the self. In the cultural industry, pop music demonstrates hybridity, commodification, and media involvement, features that keep pop music alive

and influential across different borders (Wan Nur Syaza Sahira Wan Rusli & Azianura Hani Shaari, 2018).

The notion of “pop music” (nhạc trẻ) was coined in Vietnam in the 1960s due to the influence of pop and rock music in the West. After a time interval of interruption, Vietnamese pop music experienced its revival in the late 1980s. In this regard, some representatives of the field such as Mỹ Linh, Lam Trường, Hồng Nhung, and Phương Thanh should be highlighted. With the onset of the 21st century, V-pop became the icon of the nation’s popular music combining K-pop, R&B, EDM, and hip-hop. Therefore, it is evident that the idea of cultural globalization is prominent here.

Since 2018, the rise of new media tools like YouTube, Spotify, and TikTok has made it possible for the Vietnamese pop music industry to witness the dawn of “aesthetic globalization.” It means that listeners now participate in creating pop songs through remixing and covers and sharing memes on social media. Structures of melodies have changed, and many features of different types are combined. In such conditions, language, especially code-mixing, can be regarded as the major means of sense-making.

4.3. Findings on code-mixing in Vietnamese Youth Music

4.3.1. Survey Procedure for Linguistic code-mixing in Vietnamese Pop Songs

For the purpose of understanding the semantics of code-mixing in the Vietnamese youth music lyrics of 2018-2023, a two-stage research design has been implemented to ensure consistency in data collection and systematic analysis of results.

Stage 1: Data Collection and Selection

As previously indicated, code-mixing data in Vietnamese youth music was taken mostly from YouTube because of its popularity among modern popular music consumers. Lyrics of all songs were transcribed and formatted to be further subjected to analysis. Thus, a total of 431 songs containing English code-mixing were gathered for further semantic analysis to represent the range of tendencies of current Vietnamese pop music.

Stage 2: Classification and Semantic Analysis of Code-Mixing

At the second stage, code-mixed units were classified and analyzed according to three main perspectives: linguistic, grammatical, and semantic.

Initially, the languages used, code-mixing positions, and their frequency per song were considered. Results show that English was the most frequently occurring language among other foreign codes; the frequency of Korean, Japanese, Chinese, and French occurred lower but still was noticeable. In 2023, examples of Spanish, Portuguese, Greek, Russian, Hindi, Arabic, Polish, and Brazilian Portuguese have appeared as well. However, as already mentioned, the analysis will concentrate primarily on English code-mixing.

Secondly, mixed codes were examined according to grammatical structures as well as their semantic features. Regarding grammatical aspects, three types of mixing were found in lyrics: single words, phrases, and clauses. From the semantic perspective, layers of meanings, expressive functions, and communication purposes were analyzed considering particular situations in which the code-mixing occurs. This procedure has been performed simultaneously with the grammatical one to keep the connection between the structure and semantics of code-mixing. Semantic groups were analyzed quantitatively, including the number of codes and their distribution ratios, and qualitatively, based on their expressional functions and cultural connotations. Content analysis of data was accompanied by its semantic decoding.

Despite the large amount of manually processed data, which could cause some inaccuracies in analysis, cross-referencing has been done throughout the research to ensure consistency and accuracy regarding the semantic analysis of code-mixing in Vietnamese youth music lyrics.

4.3.2. Statistical Classification of English code-mixing in Vietnamese Youth Songs

Through the survey and semantic analysis, the study produced the following statistical summary of results:

Table 1. Semantic Categories of code-mixed Elements in Vietnamese Youth Music

No	Semantic Field	Number of code-mixed Units	Percentage (%)
1	Emotional states	773	15.37
2	Fashion and beauty	193	3.84

3	Lifestyle	457	9.09
4	Social relationships	954	18.97
5	Art	625	12.43
6	Science	513	10.20
7	Dreams and aspirations	24	0.48
8	Actions and behaviors	957	19.03
9	Occupations	54	1.07
10	Space and time	322	6.40
11	Food and cuisine	158	3.14
Total		5030	100

From the information given above in Table 1 about code-mixed words used in Vietnamese youth music between 2018 and 2023, it becomes clear that there is a wide range of semantic fields associated with code-mixing phenomena. This means that young generations are creative and flexible when communicating through music since there are high-frequency semantic classes such as actions (19.03%), social relations (18.97%), emotions (15.37%), and art (12.43%). However, it should be noted that such a classification system is flexible due to several reasons:

- *First*, the existence of semantic fluidity and polysemy makes many expressions applicable to several semantic classes simultaneously.

- *Second*, emotions play a crucial role in songs rather than exact meaning so that most terms have a number of symbolic interpretations that cannot be classified.

- *Third*, hybrid semantic fields emerge due to the convergence of modern topics like technology, social networks, and popular culture in everyday reality.

This means that the purpose of using such a semantic field classification lies in the possibility to structure the information provided above and analyze expressive features of Vietnamese youth music as a form of discourse. Therefore, further consideration will include the most frequent semantic fields among those discussed above.

4.4. Semantic Characteristics of code-mixed Elements in Vietnamese Youth Music

4.4.1. The “Action” Semantic Group

Of all the semantic fields considered in the analysis, action forms the most common category with 957 tokens (19.03%). Some examples of lexical units include make up, listen, order, check, pick up the phone, chill, feel my love, care, love you, and miss you, indicating the dynamism and immediacy typical of modern life.

This dominance can be explained by the role of verbs in conveying actions and states that are associated with emotions and cognition necessary for lyrical song writing. Contemporary youth songs often have lyrical subjects who are self-involved and emotive, in which case the verbs used in the lyrics effectively depict the changes in their mental or emotional states. Feel, miss, and love are some of the verbs that capture complex emotions in brief terms, resulting in immediate expressiveness. Therefore, English verbs in the Vietnamese lyrics convey the process of emotional thinking that is immediate and active – features typical of youth music.

4.4.2. The “Social Relationship” Semantic Group

Following the topic of social relationship is the second most frequent group (954 words; 18.97%) including such common vocabulary like mama, baby, baby girl, bestie, and homie. Words included in this social relationship group reveal features of intimate connections between family members, lovers, or friends.

From the semantic perspective, words that code-mixers apply from this category meet the demands of young audiences when listening to modern songs by providing the possibility of expressing affection in an internationally understood vocabulary that would make the lyrics sound fresh and modern. In particular, words like baby or homie not only bring about the renewal of lyrical expression but also reveal the redefinition of affection performed by the younger generation who uses language as an international means of communication where love and friendship serve as cultural concepts.

To conclude, code-mixed expressions referring to the topic of social relationships imply emotions and sociocultural connotations. Since almost all of the selected words pertain to the nominal group, they easily fit the syntax structure of Vietnamese language making their rhythm sound more natural.

4.4.3. The “Emotional State” Semantic Group

Emotions are among the most frequently used semantological groups, represented by 773 examples (15.37%). Examples of code-mixing emotions through such phrases as “oh baby”, “sorry”, “oh my God”, “lonely”, “broken” and “tired” cover the whole range of feelings including happiness and desire for somebody or something as well as loneliness and distress. Emotional code-mixing in lyrical discourse is considered to be more expressive and genuine. English words being laconic and distinctive have an instant effect on listeners’ emotions. Thus, performers have an opportunity to create the image of their modern lyrical self as free, honest and unrestricted by any norms.

In the age of digital technologies, where emotions change very quickly and are spread through social networks, the usage of emotions in code-mixing is also a kind of connection between the creator and his listeners. Thus, in addition to being a way of personal expression, music becomes a source of consolation for young people whose life style is hectic and tense.

4.4.4. The “Artistic” Semantic Group

Furthermore, among other groups mentioned above, the artistic semantic field is another notable feature of Vietnamese youth music in the years from 2018 to 2023, which represents 625 examples (12.43%) and takes the fourth place in terms of frequency of use.

Examples of code-mixed lexical units belonging to the field in question involve musical and performing processes such as micro, fan, melody, beat, idol, and showbiz. Not only do those words imbue linguistic expression with cosmopolitan color, but they also demonstrate language and culture contact in interactions between Vietnamese performers and the world of music.

In many songs, such terms serve as linguistic signs of identity in the music field as well as a declaration of the emergence of new generations of performers in the form of rapper, lyrics, flow in Không Ai Bỏ Được Hip-Hop (Da LAB) or Siêu Sao (HIEUTHUAI). Artistic code-mixing serves as an indicator of defining modern aesthetics and expanding the range of expression as well as increasing artistic merit of Vietnamese youth lyrics.

4.4.5. Less Frequent Semantic Groups

Apart from these major categories, code-mixing in Vietnamese youth music between 2018 and 2023 also involves five other groups that occur less often but are semantically relevant: science, lifestyle, space-time, fashion-beauty, and food.

Science and technology (513 uses, 10.20%) represent the impact of technology and its practices on the spirituality of the younger generation. Code-mixed elements like wifi, Google, follow, update, and system error convey both actions and, more importantly, the way of life connected to digital technology. Many of these elements have flexible meanings and can be used metonymically (crash, follow), thus creating additional layers of meaning and showing how technology became a kind of emotional context for language and life.

Lifestyle (9.09%) is represented by terms that speak of individualism and identity, such as cool, bad boy, lowkey, and chill. These code-mixed terms contribute to constructing an image of an independent artist.

Space-time (6.40%) represents terms related to spatial and temporal dimensions, such as Cali, Kyoto, midnight, and Sunday, creating a multidimensional cultural space.

Fashion-beauty (3.84%) corresponds to the aesthetics characteristic of contemporary music. Words like make up, crop top, Dior, and flawless beauty describe not only visual style but also artistic personality.

Finally, **the food group** (3.14%)—coffee, sushi, matcha, and champagne—are examples of fusion of cultures in the East and West. This set of terms can be seen as “spiritual travel” through language and music.

In general, these groups of terms are enrich the semantic and expressive spectrum of Vietnamese youth music, portraying *a linguistically hybrid, multilayered, and evocative world* of contemporary expression.

4.5. Decoding the Relationship Between Semantics and Artistic Choice in Youth Music

Code-mixing in the Vietnamese youths' music is not just a stylistic feature; it is rather a complex expressive tool that reveals the aesthetic perceptions of artists and the semantic intent of the lyrical lines. There are three major roles played by code-mixing with foreign languages in the Vietnamese songs:

The first function is related to the ability of artists to convey emotions or some ideas more efficiently using code-mixing. It turns out that some emotions could not be translated into the Vietnamese words adequately because there exist special connotations in foreign lexemes that could not be conveyed through other means. Thus, I'm fine in I'm Fine Thank You by Hòa Minzy implies not only a state of being calm but also an emotion of loneliness, and sorry in Anh Không Tha Thứ by Đình Dũng signifies feelings of regret and remorse. In short, code-mixing could be viewed as an effective instrument for conveying emotions in a compact form.

The second purpose of introducing English words into Vietnamese lyrics is economy of linguistic expressions combined with enhanced semantic richness. Such monosyllabic lexemes as love, dream, and bye have large semantic fields. For example, love means the same as tình yêu, dream – giấc mơ, bye – tạm biệt. Due to their brevity and musical quality, such words are used more often. Hence, it seems logical that code-mixing serves to save the necessary time without losing the emotional colorfulness.

Thirdly, code-mixing brings to music a multicultural and modern aesthetic perception. The combination of two languages in songs illustrates the life of people who belong to both Vietnam and the rest of the world. Examples of mixed linguistic expressions like baby oi, don't leave me from Amee (Anh Nhà Ở Đầu Thế) and let me love you from

Rhymastic (Yêu 5) reveal how Vietnamese emotions sound in foreign words and vice versa. Therefore, code-mixing becomes not just a stylistic device but a cultural one too.

5. Conclusion

The existence of code-mixing in the lyrics of music songs used by the Vietnamese youth from 2018 till 2023 has been established through systematic inquiry and study. Such usage has been regarded as an indicator of natural language development and interaction, as well as an integral component of artistic perception of young generations. The use of code-mixing is considered a means of developing creative expression, which allows young musicians to create their personal linguistic world.

First, it is necessary to stress that code-mixing is not a mere fusion of two linguistic systems. Code-mixing represents a peculiar method, with the help of which one can create new opportunities in communication. Code-mixing allows one to convey his/her thoughts efficiently, combining Vietnam's emotional coloration with global symbols and thereby creating unique shades, which cannot be achieved through another way. Thus, the frequent usage of certain lexes, such as love, sorry, baby, dream, and forever, is conditioned by their meaningfulness and ability to express universally common things, characteristic of modernity.

The mixture of the Vietnamese language with English contributes to the creation of the multi-cultural context, which helps in constant transformation of national identity due to continuous interaction with the outer world. From this perspective, code-mixing represents not only an element of expressing something but also the means of creating imagery and character within the musical culture.

To conclude, studying the semantic aspect of code-mixing in the lyrics used by young people can be regarded as the decoding of the younger generation's attitude towards themselves and the outside world. It should be stressed that code-mixing is not just a language pollution but also its vitality and adaptability.

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